

General Damodar Rout. The BJP's senior leader Bishwabhusan Harichandan tried to save face by declaring that the party had decided to target assembly elections 2014 but that was clearly a weak ploy in the face of its woeful performance. It won only six Assembly seats and drew a blank in the Lok Sabha against its tally of seven in 2004.

According to political analysts, what helped the BJD's clean sweep were a series of measures that benefited the poor and added to Patnaik's pro-people image. The Patnaik Government had introduced a scheme to sell rice at a subsidised rate of Rs 2 a kg whose direct beneficiaries were 55 lakh poor families in the state. Besides, there was Patnaik's favourite 'Mission Shakti', aimed at empowering women. Under the scheme, over 48 lakh women were organised under self-help groups that empowered them socially and economically. A new phenomenon was witnessed among tribals in the interiors who are traditional Congress supporters and still

worship Indira Gandhi as "Indira maa". This time, Patnaik's pro-poor schemes succeeded in switching their loyalties to the BJD. The BJD also gained since neither the Congress nor the BJP projected a credible face as an alternate chief ministerial candidate. The Congress, while failing to cross its 2004 tally of 38 assembly seats, did increase its tally of Lok Sabha from two to five, indicating that the electorate looked beyond the state when voting for the Lok Sabha.

While Patnaik's victory is a vindication of his decision to go it alone, there is one other person who deserves credit: Pyarimohan Mohapatra, a former bureaucrat and his one-man think tank. Mohapatra was the one who recommended ditching the BJP which he felt had become a drag on Patnaik's secular image. He also conducted the survey which showed the advantages of the split for the BJD. The survey showed that 79 per cent of the people in the state had voted for the alliance in the name of Patnaik and only 21 per cent for the BJP. About 66 per cent said

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Orissa should be ruled by one party (BJD) and 62 per cent in urban areas and 60 per cent in rural areas favoured Patnaik as chief minister.

The assembly results have once again proved that there is no alternative to good performance and good governance. Even Patnaik admitted this, saying it was a vote for his government's implementation of pro-poor schemes. He has also done a lot towards improving rural electrification and roads. He, in fact, borrowed a slogan from Sanjay Gandhi, "Talk less, work more", which describes his own personal style of governance. This coupled with his simple lifestyle worked in his favour. In fact, there is a distinct 'Patnaik Style'. He is the only chief minister in the country who has depoliticised politics. Even during the distribution of tickets he did not call a meeting of the Political Affairs Committee. Instead, it was he in consultation with Mohapatra who decided on allocation of tickets. That is part of a long-term strategy to weed out BJD leaders with unsavoury reputations, a strategy which adds to his own clean image. In conjunction, he has attracted a large number of businessmen and investors competing with each other to set up steel, aluminium, power, alloy and chrome plants in what is a mineral-rich state.

His biggest weapon, however, remains his unwavering commitment to fight for the interest of the state and its people. Soon after the results were out, Patnaik was asked if he would be playing a bigger role in Central politics. His answer: "We are a regional party. The Centre must protect Orissa's interest." He now has the political clout to chase that ambition. ■